be taken into consideration. I tell you – the Soviet Union needs enlargement of her security guarantee system; for this purpose she needs an exit from the Baltic Sea.'[57]

The same excuse was used against Finland (which could easily be described as an Eastern European country, given its geographic position and its relationship with Russia) and that country was eventually forced to surrender some of its eastern territories. Bordering neutral Sweden on the west, Finland's main worries about security also concerned the Soviet Union, not Germany. Following its experience in 1940, Finland sided with Germany (although it was far from embracing Nazi ideology) and declared war on the Soviet Union in 1941, as did Hungary and Slovakia and (later) Romania. Who would have imagined that 80 years later Finland, neutral for many years, would again feel threatened by Russia and decide to join NATO?

In the whole Baltic area, countries were obliged to reach some kind of compromise with Nazi Germany in order to save themselves from what to them was the prime danger – the Soviet Union. In some cases – although this was not true everywhere – such compromise involved taking part in oppression and handing over local Jews to the Nazis, a reflection of the desperate position of these small countries caught between Nazi Germany on the one hand and the Soviet Union on the other. In Lithuania, approximately 94% of the nation's Jews perished in the Holocaust. In Latvia, almost the entire Jewish population died during the Nazi occupation.[58] (The French Vichy police too, in much less dramatic circumstances, assisted in the deportation of Jews and there were cases of collaboration with the Nazis in other Western European and Scandinavian countries. Many European nation-states do not exactly have a record in such matters that can bear too much examination.[59]) As far as the Baltics are concerned, the dominant narrative about this period of time is one of the 'residents being cornered into self-defence after victimisation at the hands of two militarily superior invading forces'.[60] But this 'neat narrative can stir unease through these attempts to whitewash the past'.[61] Indeed, the prevailing memory in the region today is that of the brutality of the Soviet occupation, which Putin's Russia continues to skilfully use in its approach to the three countries,[62] accusing them of relativising the Nazi aggression and its crimes.